

Aural Aura

Agent 001 mulls over hitting the right note

Recently, I was at a friend's house for a UT 2003 LAN party. Of course, this friend is one of those people who can deflate your ego in a nanosecond. He has six gaming rigs, and one personal PC. The gaming rigs are standard high performance machines, made-to-order, for one purpose only—gaming. His personal computer, on the other hand, has the latest and best hardware, a 19-inch flat monitor, 7.1 speakers with bass that can knock the breath out of you, etc.

On my way home, after eight gruelling hours of splattering and being splattered by rocket launchers, I realised that I have almost as good a PC configuration as him—the difference between amazing and average was just the sound power and quality. While I was busy scrounging, scrimping and saving money to buy faster RAM, faster and larger hard drives, faster CPU, the best motherboard, a 9800 Pro graphics card and a huge monitor, my friend outsmarted me with amazing audio. My mind was made up—I would take a trip to Mumbai's Lamington Road the next day to get that perfect sound.

I walked into the first shop that displayed speakers, and told them that I wanted the best sound solution that my money could buy. He suggested a Creative SoundBlaster 4.1 Digital sound card with Creative Inspire 4.1 speakers. The cost: Rs 1,200 and Rs 3,000 respectively. He suggested the Creative SBS 2.1 370 as well, for Rs 1,550. I promptly demanded more, and the best he came up with was the Creative SoundBlaster Live 5.1 SE

sound card and Creative Inspire 5.1 speakers—Rs 2,070 and Rs 4,700, respectively. He told me that I could opt for Altec Lansing speakers, but they were more expensive and didn't offer any performance gains over the Creative sets. According to him, Frontech and Mercury were just cheap, but did nothing for the ears of even the most amateur of audiophiles.

From here on, almost every shop I went into said exactly the same thing. Some

just because it offered an FM tuner. "You can listen to radio even when the PC is off, what more can you want?", asked one. Frustrated, muttering under my breath about morons selling onions and potatoes instead of superbly crafted hardware, I plodded on.

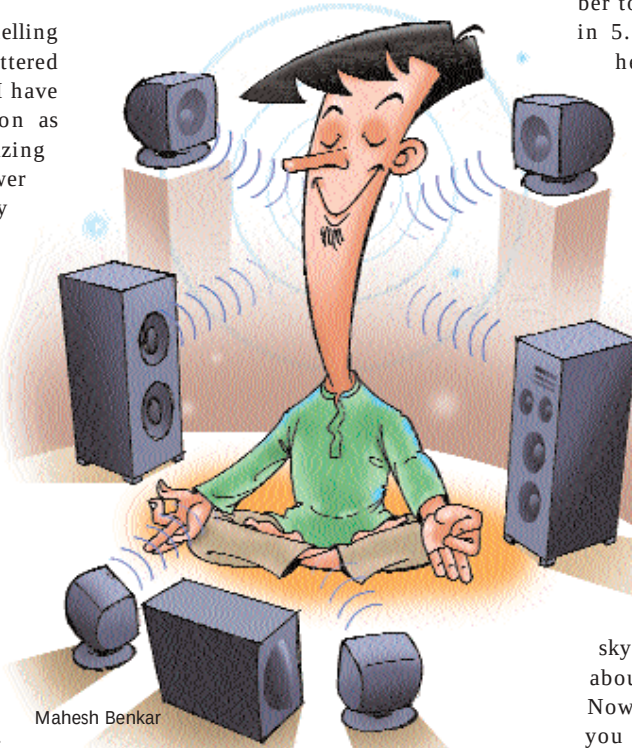
The next guy suggested a JBL PRO 2.1 speakers. "Nice," I thought. "Only Rs 9,500", he added. "Umm, not so nice after all. Breathe, breathe, must remember to breathe", I told myself. "Nothing in 5.1?", I asked aloud. He shook his head. Relieved, I darted for the exit.

I saw a guy walking out of the smallest looking shop on the road, carrying a large carton that screamed Artis 5.1. I walked in to find a young man of about 24 behind the counter.

The shop had everything you could dream of, all precariously stacked and balanced right up to the ceiling. The guy also seemed to know his stuff. The store was crowded with about two people, so I waited my turn politely. When he nodded at me, I asked for the best sound solution available. "Depends, on your budget", he shot back. "The sky's the limit", I replied. "OK then, how about a Creative 7.1 solution?" he asked.

Now we're talking! I asked to see it. "Have you noticed some space in here that I haven't?" he asked, and with a smile started dialling four and eight digit numbers randomly.

He finally gave up and told me that there were none available off hand, and there would be a minimum waiting period of 15 days. He wouldn't give me the price, saying, "Fifteen days is a lifetime in this business, the price could double, halve or remain the same. Give me your phone number, and I will call you as soon as they're available." I left the number and went home. Now, I'm way too excited in expectation of the 7.1s, and terrified of the price he's going to quote. "The sky's the limit indeed!", me and my motor-mouth! ■



even suggested the Frontechs. Oblivious to things such as frequency response and RMS power, they insisted it was a good buy



- Ensure that you have the requisite connectors on your sound card or onboard audio, before you buy a speaker set, especially if you are buying a 4.1 or a higher system. Basic speakers need only one connector, while the 4.1 and 5.1 systems have three connectors.
- Make sure that you get the original cords and connectors, as they also affect

the quality of the sound dramatically.

- If you are buying stands for the speakers, ensure that the satellite speakers sit on them rigidly.
- Insist on a demo before buying, and if possible, at the place where you are going to install it.
- Buy noise-cancellation headphones—similar to those used in airlines—if you plan to use headphones in a noisy area.